of the 2004 Indian Ocean tsunami. Ever since then, each ship, irrespective of its primary mission, carries a HADR brick comprising essentials such as food, water, blankets and medicines. Seeing the developing situation, Indian naval ships INS *Rana* and *Kirpan* had been pre-positioned at Port Blair. They set sail on 5 May, reaching Yangon on 7 May, the first international assistance to reach Yangon. To do so, they had to navigate the tidal channel up to Yangon, which was littered with the wrecks of ships that had either capsized or sunk at their moorings. On reaching, not only did they discharge their cargo but also conducted a medical camp at a nearby local ground. Their conduct was the epitome of professionalism. The Defence Wing had to coordinate all these efforts even without a roof over our own heads, and with no water or electricity. In the midst of all this, Ambassador Bhaskar Mitra had a brilliant idea of taking diesel from the Indian ships. We rounded up all the empty barrels that we could find using our local contacts, hired a pick-up truck and got about a dozen 200-litre barrels of diesel topped up. With this, we were able to run our generators and restore power to the embassy. The military junta, though, refused permission for the American warship USS *Essex* and a host of other warships, as well as ships of international aid agencies to enter their international waters. These ships had to offload their cargo into smaller local vessels. This only demonstrated the goodwill that India had generated through its sustained engagement with Myanmar.

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International aid continued to pour in by land, sea and air. Several IAF aircraft, AN-32s and Il-76s, landed at Yangon carrying relief stores. India also sent a field hospital, which did yeoman service in some of the worst affected parts of the Ayeyarwady Delta. I was a bit disappointed with the Air Force, though. The pilots of one of the early sorties, after parking the